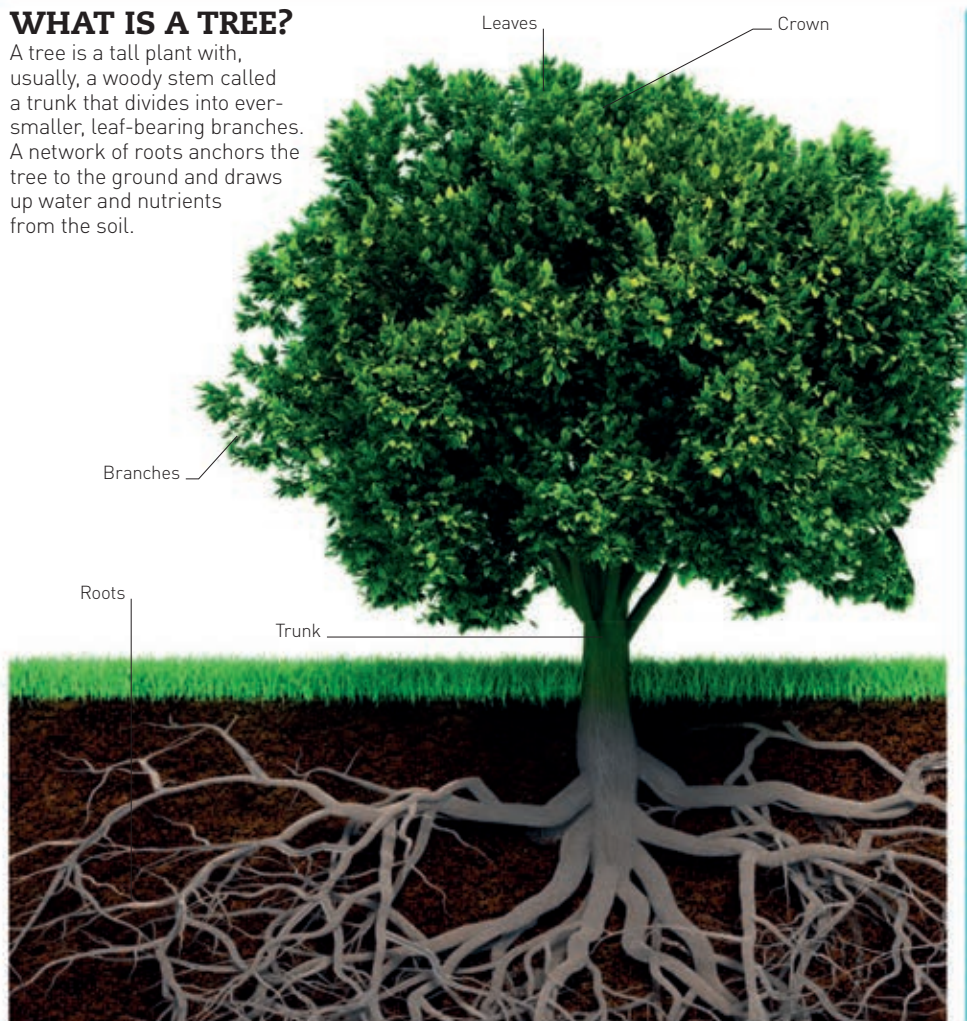


Trees

The largest plants on Earth, trees have been here for millions of years. They are vital to the planet's survival. Their leaves absorb harmful substances from the atmosphere and produce oxygen. Trees keep the air moist, which helps to create rainfall, and provide homes and food for wildlife.

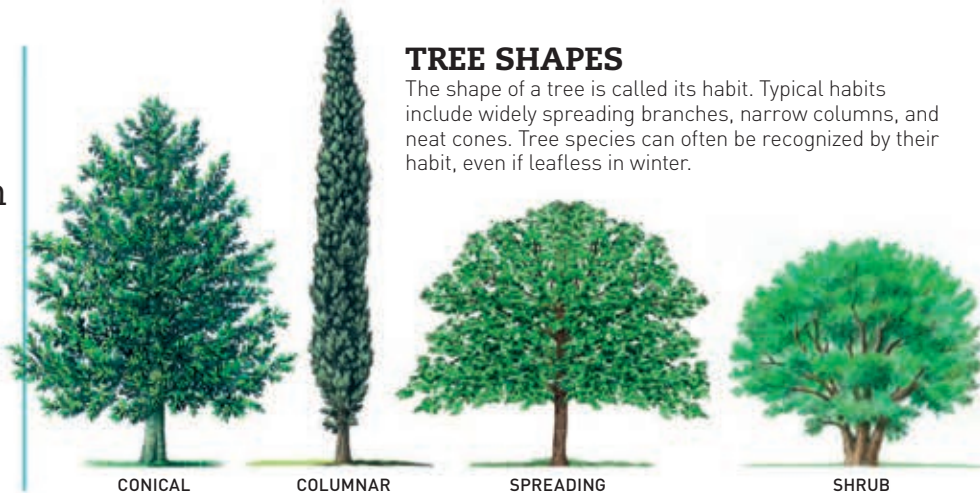
WHAT IS A TREE?

A tree is a tall plant with, usually, a woody stem called a trunk that divides into ever-smaller, leaf-bearing branches. A network of roots anchors the tree to the ground and draws up water and nutrients from the soil.



TREE SHAPES

The shape of a tree is called its habit. Typical habits include widely spreading branches, narrow columns, and neat cones. Tree species can often be recognized by their habit, even if leafless in winter.



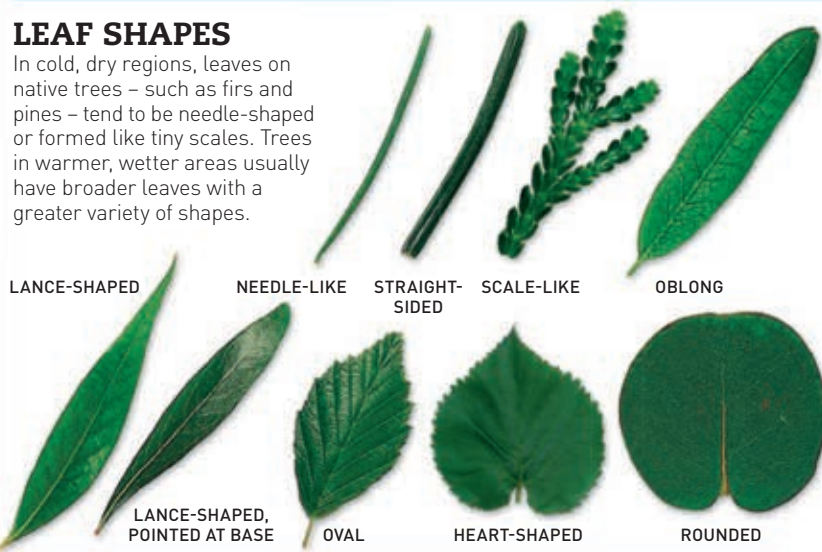
TYPES OF BARK

Bark is the outer layer of a tree. It protects the trunk and branches from damage and keeps in water. The colour and texture of bark, and the way it flakes or peels, can help with the identification of a tree. The appearance of bark can change as a tree gets older.



LEAF SHAPES

In cold, dry regions, leaves on native trees – such as firs and pines – tend to be needle-shaped or formed like tiny scales. Trees in warmer, wetter areas usually have broader leaves with a greater variety of shapes.



TREE RINGS

Every year that a tree grows it adds a new layer of wood beneath its bark. If the tree is cut down, these layers can be seen as dark and light rings. By counting the dark rings, it is possible to work out the age of the tree.

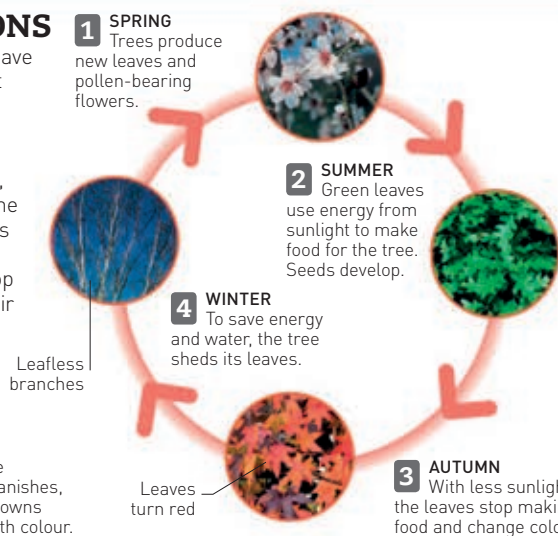


FOUR SEASONS

Many types of trees have a cycle of growth that follows seasonal weather changes. They produce leaves and flowers in spring, then seeds through the summer. As the hours of daylight shorten in autumn, the trees stop growing and drop their leaves. In winter, the trees have a period of rest.

LEAF CHANGE

In autumn, leaves change appearance. The green vanishes, and reds, yellows, and browns make woodlands glow with colour.



TALLEST TREES

The evergreen trees known as Coastal Redwoods grow taller than any other species of tree. They grow naturally only along the Pacific coast of northern California, USA. The very tallest redwood is an amazing 116 m (380 ft) high. Named Hyperion, its exact location is secret.

HYPERION REDWOOD
116 m (380 ft)

